Shaozhe Cheng

Curriculum Vitae
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Department of Psychology & Neuroscience
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Positions

Postdoc Scholar, UCLA & Duke University 2024-
Collaborators: Tao Gao, Michael Tomasello & Tamar Kushnir

Education

Ph.D., Cognitive Psychology, Zhejiang University 2023
Advisors: Jifan Zhou (ZJU), Mowei Shen (ZJU), Tao Gao (UCLA)
Dissertation: *On the nature and origins of the unique human mind: Intentional commitment under conflicting desires* **(Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award)**

B.S., Psychology, Shanghai Normal University 2016

Awards and Honors

- Early-Career Scholar, Intentions & AI Workshop 2025
- Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award of Zhejiang Province 2024
- Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award of Zhejiang University 2023
- Grant for Excellence in Doctoral Research 2022
- Cognitive Science Society Conference Award 2021
- National Scholarship for Postgraduates 2017

Research Interests

What makes the human mind and intelligence unique? I draw on theories and methods from philosophy, evolutionary theory, psychology (cognitive, social, developmental, and computational), and artificial intelligence to explore the nature and origins of human agency. By integrating behavioral and computational approaches, I aim to bridge human and artificial intelligence by uncovering the foundations of uniquely human agentic structures and their significance in self- and social coordination, with the goal of advancing more human-like and human-compatible AI systems.

Publications

Under Review

Cheng, S., Gao T., Tomasello, M., & Kushnir, T. (under review). The Agency Gap: Testing Human–Human and Human–AI Collaboration Using a Minimal Coordination Game. (presented as a **spotlight** research talk (top 10%) at Conference on Society-Centered AI.)

Tomasello, M., & **Cheng, S.** (invited submission). Can We Get to Human-Like Intelligence Via Language Alone?

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (under review). Should we commit or should we switch? Goal alignment in sequential social coordination. (6-page paper accepted as a **talk** (9.3%) at *CogSci* 2026)

Journal Articles

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2026). Spontaneous coordination with self-commitment: How the presence of others alters the strength, goal and timing of commitment. *Cognition. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2025.106287*

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Tang, N., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2023). Intention beyond desire: Spontaneous intentional commitment regulates conflicting desires. *Cognition*, 238, 105513. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2023.105513

Zhai, S[#]., **Cheng, S[#].**, Moskowitz, N., Shen, M., & Gao, T. (2024). The development of commitment: Attention for intention. *Child Development*, 95(1), 7-15. https://doi.org/10.1111/cdev.13955
[#] Shared first authors

Cheng, S., Shi, B., Zhao, Y., Tang, N., Xu., H., Gao, T., Zhou J., & Shen, M. (2017) Rethinking attention: A reinforcement learning model of attention. *Chinese Journal of Applied Psychology.*

Peer-Reviewed Conference Proceedings

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2024). Intentional commitment as a spontaneous presentation of self. In *Proceedings of the 46th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society.*

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2022). Intentional commitment through an internalized theory of mind: Acting in the eyes of an imagined observer. In *Proceedings of the 44th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society.*

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2022). Intentional commitment as goal perseverance in human planning [Workshop on Social Intelligence in Humans and Robots]. *The annual meeting of the Robotics: Science and Systems 2022 (RSS 2022). Virtual: Workshop RSS 2022*. (presented as a **spotlight** paper at https://social-intelligence-human-ai.github.io/)

Zhai, S., **Cheng, S.**, Moskowitz, N., Shen, M., & Gao, T. (2022). The development of commitment: Attention for intention. In *Proceedings of the 44th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society.*

Cheng, S., Tang, N., An, W., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2021). Intention beyond desire: Humans Spontaneously Commit to Future Actions. In *Proceedings of the 43rd Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society.*

In Preparation

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (in prep). Modeling intentions through an internalized theory of mind: Acting in the eyes of an imagined observer.

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (in prep). Viewing others as committed agents.

Conference Presentations

^Students I supervised

Cheng, S., Main, K^., Kushnir, T., & Gao, T. (2025, May). Spontaneous social coordination through visually grounded theory-of-mind in children's and adults' decision-making. Poster accepted at *the Annual Meeting of the Vision Sciences Society*, St. Pete Beach, Florida, USA.

Cheng, S., Main, K^., Gao, T., & Kushnir, T. (2025, May). Children's Spontaneous Commitment and Intention Coordination in Individual and Social Decision-Making Contexts. Talk at the Symposium: Unravelling early and middle childhood decision-making: From individual characteristics to social influences, *Society for Research in Child Development Biennial Meeting (SRCD 2025)*, Minneapolis, MN, USA.

Cheng, S., Zhu, J^., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2024). From attention capture to social coordination: "Abrupt onset" rallies joint planning. Poster presented at *the 2024 VSS Annual Meeting. Vision Sciences Society.*

Zhu, J^., **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). Viewing others as committed agents. Poster presented at *the 2023 SPSP Annual Convention. Society for Personality and Social Psychology*.

Zhu, J^., **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). Intention as hierarchical constraints in human planning. Poster presented at *the 2023 VSS Annual Meeting. Vision Sciences Society.*

Zhu, J^., **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shui, R., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). People expect others to plan with consistency to intention. Poster presented at *the 2023 APS Annual Convention. Association for Psychological Science.*

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Zhu, J^., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2022). Intentional commitment as goal perseverance in human planning. Oral presentation at the Workshop on Social Intelligence in Humans and Robots in the *annual meeting of the Robotics: Science and Systems 2022 (RSS 2022).* https://social-intelligence-human-ai.github.io/

Zhai, S., **Cheng, S.**, Moskowitz, N., Shen, M., & Gao, T. (2022). The development of commitment: Attention for intention. Oral presentation at *the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Cheng, S., Tang, N., An, W., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2021). Intention beyond desire: Commitment in human action. Poster presented at *the 47th annual meeting of the Society for Philosophy and Psychology*, 6/28/21 – 7/2/21, *Virtual-SPP*.

Cheng, S., Tang, N., An, W., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2020). Intention beyond desire: Commitment in human action. Poster presented at *the annual meeting of the Vision Sciences Society*, 6/19/20 – 6/24/20, *Virtual-VSS*.

Cheng, S., Xu, H., Tang, N., Zhou J., Chen, H., Liang, J., Gao T., & Shen, M. (2018). Hierarchical Constrains on the Distribution of Attention in Dynamic Displays. Poster presented at *the 30th APS Annual Convention*.

Teaching

- **Advanced Psychological Research Methods (graduate course), 2019, 2020**

  Guest Lecturer, *Computational modeling in psychological research*

- **Psychology and Artificial Intelligence (undergraduate course), 2018, 2019**

  Teaching Assistant

- **Seminar on Evolutionary Psychology (undergraduate seminar), 2017, 2018**

  Guest Lecturer

Ad Hoc Reviewer

Science Robotics

Journal of Experimental Psychology: General

Cognition

The Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society

Society for Philosophy and Psychology

References

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